PROMETHEUS PARADOX

A story about virtue
By Percy Pham

INT. BRICK APARTMENT - 4TH FLOOR - NIGHT
A police car drove onto the street. Siren screamed in the silent night.

KYRON stitched the wounds
You really got your work cut out for those guys.

ARCHIE chuckled
The police… down there? Or the paramedics.

KYRON sighed
Based on the people you beat to pulp… Flip a coin

ARCHIE
Those are criminals

KYRON
Then what makes you different

ARCHIE
I didn't do what they did

KYRON didn't say anything and cut the string. He moved on to another wound without revealing any visible feelings.

ARCHIE (CONT'D)
I mean it… I track them down and punish them for something they did. They made their choice first.

KYRON
And you did the same thing.

ARCHIE
I have no other choice.

KYRON
You know… a year ago, when we first met after you saved me in that alley.

He pulled the black thread tight and snipped it with the scissors.

KYRON (CONT'D)
I asked why you had to take it so far. Beating them up… I could live with that, up to a point. But you terrorized them.

KYRON wiped the blood from the stitches with a clean pad.

KYRON (CONT'D)
When I asked you why you did it, you claimed you were fighting to clean up the street for tomorrow… But all I see is that you're just one of them. Another man burning it down.

ARCHIE
We all say that. But when it comes down to dealing with the devil, God personally sent Michael to defeat Lucifer, dragging the devil from heaven into hell, into eternal damnation.

KYRON held out the bottle of painkillers. ARCHIE shook his head and gently pushed the hand away. He then set the bottle down, walked to the kitchen table, and took a sip of water.

KYRON
You are not God. You can't just play God…

ARCHIE
But I need to do what's right.

KYRON picked up a bottle of water and tossed it to ARCHIE. He caught it, opened the bottle, and took a sip.

KYRON
But how do you know what is right? You don't know anything but your version of what's real and what's not.

ARCHIE
Prometheus stole fire for mankind. It went against Zeus, but he did it anyway because it was the right thing to do.

KYRON chuckled
The same fire that burned the Library of Alexandria to the ground. The same one that gave humans the strength over all other creatures, simply because Prometheus preferred us over his brother's work.

ARCHIE stayed quiet, staring down at the floor in anger before his expression went completely hollow, wearing the look of a man who had lost his faith.

KYRON took his glasses off and rubbed the bridge of his nose
Look... We don't get to just look at someone and decide who they are. Our first lesson is always to learn to be the opposite of who we naturally are. Sure, some change, and some stay the same. Some turn out good, while others stay bad or turn bad.

ARCHIE stood up and put on his black T-shirt.

KYRON (CONT'D)
Isn't that your job? To give them hope? To guide people away from their sins before they fall any deeper, instead of letting your wrath run free?

ARCHIE
You know nothing about my job. Do you know what the worst part is?

KYRON took the black denim hoodie off the chair and threw it at ARCHIE. He caught it and pulled it on.

KYRON looked out the window
What?

ARCHIE
Sitting in that tiny box. Listening to helpless women and children crying for help... Listening to rapists and murderers taunting me while I had to sit there and do nothing. This is not how it should be.

KYRON
Van Gogh died broke. People laughed at him and his work, and didn't realize the beauty of what he was building until long after he was gone. Sometimes a design takes time to take shape and reveal itself.

ARCHIE walked to the window and jumped onto the fire escape. KYRON turned toward the chair where he had just treated ARCHIE, gathering his medical instruments, packing them away, and throwing away the trash.

ARCHIE turned back to KYRON
But at the end of the day... people will always chase their sin. And all they can do is atone for it. That is what we are made for: living with remorse. I don't pretend to know God's plan. But I know that they need to regret what they did. Through guilt... or through fear.